

BOLD CONVERSATIONS

REC VS.
COMPETITIVE.

Gabby Cole × Coach Nev · 63:08

THE REAL QUESTION

EVERYONE SAYS THEY
WANT
TO BE COMPETITIVE.

Nobody has stopped to ask what that actually means.

This is Gabby and Coach Nev a leadership and volleyball coach from Birmingham, Alabama going an hour deep on one of the most misused words in youth sports.

WHAT YOU WILL HEAR

19 TOPIC SHIFTS. 63 MINUTES.

0:00	What competitive actually means	~20:00	The bench and what competitive really means
2:13	The farm analogy what commitment costs	31:16	The playing time conversation
3:23	Spring break and who is actually competitive	~38:00	Development and parent-filled intake forms
4:21	Rec is not dirty pretending is the problem	46:05	Parent education who is responsible?
5:21	Be obsessed or be average	~52:00	Two different tracks on the same team
5:51	Defining the lanes	54:53	The Olympic setter story
6:22	The club dilution problem	56:39	The invisible thing on the court
7:30	Separating parent ego from athlete development	58:17	The solution clear lanes
8:32	Getting offended by the word fundamental	59:16	Coaches your time is valuable, say so
~10:00	Who defines the levels?		

HEAR THIS ONCE

COMPETITIVE IS NOT A LABEL.
IT IS A STATE OF BEING.

"You are always looking at your activity in relation to a goal. You are not just showing up."

"For me, competitive is a state of being. If I cook, I want to make the best lunch ever. There is a drive you are always looking for the next level." Coach Nev

THE ANALOGY + THE LANES

EVERYBODY WANTS THE FARM LIFE.
NOBODY WANTS TO SHOVEL.

THE FARM

Competition is not the medal. Not the TikTok. Not the cute pic. It is grueling work. Skipping spring break. Showing up when everyone else is at the beach.

THE PROBLEM

Being in a competitive space with a recreational mindset. Not rec itself. Pretending. The word rec feels below their pride so everyone calls themselves competitive.

THE FIX

Define the lanes. Name them differently if you have to. People need to know where they are before they can choose where they want to go.

THE BENCH CONVERSATION · 31:16

SIX PLAY.

SIX SIT.

THAT IS COMPETITIVE.

130 people tried out. 12 made the team. You earn your spot.

Coach Nev put it in the contract. Held meetings. Made it clear. First time a kid was subbed to develop the team they quit. Next two days. Gone.

"That is the culture. We are pissing against the wind."

PARENT EDUCATION

IF YOU WILL NOT PAY
FOR THE EDUCATION
STOP TALKING ON THE SIDELINE.

The information is available everywhere. Coaches build the courses. Parents say they should watch them. Then say: I don't have time. Then it is not a priority. Then stop talking about what that kid is doing and how many errors she gets to make.

Athletes who say they want to be competitive not one of them has watched volleyball outside of practice this week. Zero.

TWO TRACKS + THE INVISIBLE THING

Where the drama comes from. And what actually decides who plays.

TWO TRACKS

Parents want scholarships. Kids want fun and new people. Both on the same team. When you push the kids who want fun to perform for the parents who want D1 someone is about to quit. Or be resented.

THE INVISIBLE THING

Two Olympians. Both 6'3. Both immaculate. One plays. One never sees the court. What decides it? The mental game. Leadership. How the team feels when that person is on the floor. You cannot see it. You cannot explain it. It is present at every level.

THE OLYMPIC SETTER

"I asked a Serbian national team coach: you have two setters, both professionals, both Olympians. How do you decide who plays? It is the mental game. It is leadership. It is how the team feels when that one person is on the floor."

THE SOLUTION

CLEAR LANES.
FROM DAY ONE.

ATHLETE

From her very first club season she should know why she is playing. Her honest answer. Not the impressive one.

PARENT

Be honest about why you are making the sacrifices. If you want D1 say it and be it. Do not be shy about it.

COACH / CLUB

Say clearly what you are. Rec. Semi-competitive. Competitive. And coaches your time is valuable. When you say you don't do this for the money it gets interpreted as free.

TAKEAWAYS

FOR THE ATHLETE

- Are you showing up to compete or to check boxes?
- Do you know why you actually play? Write the honest answer not the impressive one.
- Your mantra is how you let a mistake go. Not willpower. A system. That is what we are building.
- Film yourself this week. Watch it without your parents in the room. What do you see?

FOR THE PARENT

- Be honest about why you are making the sacrifices. Say it out loud to yourself.
- Your athlete is watching how you handle hard moments. Not just hers. Yours.
- If you do not know what your club is building toward ask. Then actually listen.
- Stop coaching from the stands. Your kid has a coach. Your job is different.

STARTER QUESTIONS

WRITE THESE DOWN.

- 1

What is the honest reason you or your athlete is in a competitive program?

- 2

Are the sacrifices you are making aligned with what your athlete actually wants from this season?

- 3

Does your club know what it is? Do you?

- 4

What would change in your household if rec was not a dirty word if everyone could just name where they actually are?

- 5

When your athlete makes a mistake what does she do? What do you do? Are either of those working?

THIS WEEK

DO ONE THING.

ATHLETE

Ask your coach this week: "What is the one thing you are building in me this season?" Write the answer down. Do not clean it up. Write what they actually say.

PARENT

Ask your athlete this week: "Why do you play?" Do not prompt. Do not finish the sentence. Let her answer. If she does not answer let the silence sit.

BOTH

Find out what lane your club has defined itself as. If they have not defined it that is the conversation to start.

THIS IS WHERE THE REAL WORK BEGINS

MORE BOLD
CONVERSATIONS
COMING SOON.